



## **MOTION on NOTICE**

*Submitted at the Regular Park Board Meeting on May 25, 2026*

### **Beach Safety and Marine Protection**

SUBMITTED BY: Commissioner Bastyovanszky

#### **WHEREAS**

1. Vancouver's beaches and waterfront parks support significant recreational swimming and water access, particularly at Sunset Beach and English Bay;
2. English Bay, False Creek, Spanish Banks and Stanley Park waters are increasingly shared by swimmers, paddlers, recreational boating, tourism activity, and marine wildlife including whales;
3. Vancouver's urban waterfront has become significantly more crowded and complex, while recreational marine safety awareness and infrastructure have not kept pace;
4. Sunset Beach and Spanish Banks represent some of the closest points of interaction between swimmers, paddlers, high-speed personal watercraft, and recreational boating traffic within Vancouver's urban waterfront;
5. A recent incident involving a personal high-speed watercraft striking a whale near Stanley Park heightened public concern regarding swimmer safety, marine safety, and marine wildlife protection;
6. Existing marine protection efforts in Vancouver have largely focused on commercial shipping activity and port operations, while comparatively less attention has been given to recreational vessel interactions in heavily used urban swimming areas;
7. Vancouver's marine wildlife and waterfront recreation are important components of the city's tourism economy and international reputation;
8. Responsible marine operators have demonstrated that technologies such as geo-fencing, automatic speed reduction systems, and clearly defined operating boundaries can support improved marine safety outcomes;
9. Abandoned, grounded, or derelict vessels periodically affect Vancouver beaches and nearshore recreational waters, creating environmental, navigational, and public safety concerns; and
10. Authority over marine navigation and vessel regulation primarily rests with the Government of Canada, including Transport Canada and Fisheries and Oceans Canada, together with the Vancouver Fraser Port Authority and Vancouver Police Department Marine Unit;



THEREFORE BE IT RESOLVED

- A. THAT the Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation request that Transport Canada, Fisheries and Oceans Canada, the Vancouver Fraser Port Authority, the Vancouver Police Department Marine Unit, and other relevant agencies review opportunities to improve swimmer safety, recreational marine safety, and marine wildlife protection adjacent to Vancouver beaches and park waters;
- B. THAT the Board advocate for:
  - i. enhanced swim safety buoys and protected swimming boundary infrastructure adjacent to Vancouver beaches, including Sunset Beach and Spanish Banks as areas of priority;
  - ii. expanded low-speed or no-wake measures adjacent to heavily used swimming beaches and recreational waterfront areas;
  - iii. clear and standardized public guidance regarding minimum distances from swimming beaches and whales, including consideration of 300m setbacks from swimming beaches and 400m setbacks from whales for high-speed personal watercraft;
  - iv. improved public signage, maps, and awareness information regarding whale protection, swimming areas, low-speed zones, and recreational marine safety at beaches, marinas, seawalls, and vessel launch locations;
  - v. review of recreational vessel operator education, certification, and safety awareness measures relating to marine wildlife protection and urban recreational waterways;
  - vi. consideration of whether additional operating conditions, exclusion areas, or restrictions are appropriate for high-speed personal watercraft in heavily used urban recreational waters; and
  - vii. improved interagency coordination, prevention, and timely response regarding abandoned, grounded, or derelict vessels affecting Vancouver beaches and nearshore recreational waters;
- C. THAT the Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation express its willingness to support the placement of marine safety signage, maps, and whale awareness information at appropriate beaches, parks, seawalls, and waterfront access points under Park Board jurisdiction; and
- D. THAT the Chair of the Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation communicate this request to the relevant federal, port, and marine authorities on behalf of the Board.

